

THE AI CODING MATURITY CURVE

From *vibes* to **autonomy.**

Four stages every engineering org passes through on the way to durable AI leverage. ROI doesn't compound until Level 3 — where specs, not prompts, become the unit of work.

LOW LEVERAGE

LEVEL 01

01

Vibe coding

Ad-hoc prompting. No structure. Copy, paste, ship — and hope. Output quality swings with the prompt of the day.

ad-hoc prompts copy / paste no discipline



INCONSISTENT

LEVEL 02

02

Structured prompting

Rules files in place. Boilerplate prompts. Persistent context docs. Coding standards travel with the team — outputs stop being a coin flip.

rules files prompt library context docs shared standards



REPEATABLE

► ROI UNLOCK • VALUE COMPOUNDS FROM HERE

LEVEL 03 • THE UNLOCK

03

Spec-driven development (SDD)

A phased workflow — **intent** → **plan** → **tasks** → **code**. AI drafts the specs; humans review as architects. The spec becomes the artifact; code becomes the build output. Quality, review velocity and reuse all step-change.

intent plan tasks code human-as-architect



ROI UNLOCKED

HIGH LEVERAGE

LEVEL 04

04

Autonomous AI workflows

Goal-driven agents that read state, plan, act and update themselves. Self-directed, multi-step execution with verification loops in the path. Humans set the goal and the guardrails.

goal-driven self-directed verification loops multi-step



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